

Scheduled Rides @ Bolt – Product Analysis and Recommendation

Building Reliability into Ride-Hailing Services: Strategy Proposal

1. Executive Summary

I recommend we proceed with a phased implementation of the Scheduled Rides feature. It addresses a critical user pain point; unreliability for time-sensitive trips and presents a significant opportunity to improve rider retention and capture premium value. However, success is contingent on solving the core marketplace constraint of **driver supply**, not just building a rider-facing UI. We will mitigate this risk through a disciplined, metrics-driven rollout, positioning Bolt as the most reliable platform in our key markets.

2. Problem & Business Opportunity

Rider Pain Points

Presently, Bolt's on-demand model leaves riders uncertain about availability at critical trips such as airport drop offs and hospital appointments leading to customer churn.

Driver Pain Points

Drivers experience inconsistent demand patterns such as high volumes during rush hours and low activity in between. Predictable, scheduled trips could help smooth out earnings and improve planning.

The Business Opportunity

Customer Retention: Become the solution for all trips. We hypothesize scheduling will increase 30-day retention for users who adopt it.

Capture Premium Value: Introduce a higher-margin service for users willing to pay for certainty.

Competitive Differentiation: Execute flawlessly in Europe and Africa to own the "reliability" positioning.

3. Market Opportunity & Strategy

This feature addresses a clear gap in our core operational markets, where the demand for reliable, pre-planned transportation often goes unmet by existing solutions. Our lean operational model and deep local market expertise position Bolt to deliver scheduling with a focus on reliability and efficiency that can differentiate us in the marketplace.

Successfully capturing this segment would allow us to strategically evolve our brand positioning from "affordable and fast" to "affordable, fast, and **reliable**."

The business potential is substantial, targeting high-value trips where reliability is paramount. Based on internal data for commute and airport travel, we estimate that converting even 5% of these trips from spontaneous hailing or alternative transport methods to scheduled Bolt rides could generate significant incremental annual revenue. This represents a high-value segment of our user base that is less price-sensitive and more focused on guaranteed service.

Strategic Value

1. Enhanced Loyalty: Become the trusted solution for users' most important trips, directly improving retention.
2. Premium Foundation: Establishes a platform for future premium services and loyalty programs.
3. Data Advantage: Generates rich, forward-looking demand data to optimize driver incentives and marketplace efficiency.
4. Market Defense: Strengthens our position in high-value segments like airport and corporate travel, making the Bolt ecosystem more resilient.

4. Solution Vision & Key User Stories

Our goal is to deliver certainty. Riders lock in their trip and price, then forget about it. Drivers gain visibility and higher earnings for planned work.

Rider Story: "As a rider, I want to schedule a ride for a specific future time and receive confirmation that my ride is secured, so I can stop worrying about transportation for my important appointments."

Driver Story: "As a driver, I want to see and accept scheduled ride requests in advance, so I can better plan my day and maximize my earnings with high-value trips."

Core Acceptance Criteria:

System

S1. Scheduling available 12 hours to 30 days in advance.

S2. System assigns a driver 60 minutes before pickup, with proactive notifications to both parties.

Riders

R1. Riders see a locked-in, upfront price (Standard Fare + 10% Scheduling Premium).

R2. Free cancellation for riders up to 1 hour before pickup.

R3: Proactive notifications: confirmation, 24-hour reminder, and driver assignment alert

Drivers

D1. Drivers can preview and accept trips up to 2 hours in advance.

D2. Drivers can mark availability for scheduled rides via calendar interface

5. Constraints, Risks & Mitigation

Risks & Constraints	Mitigation
Driver availability and no-shows	#1 Risk. Avoid "guarantee" language. Use a pricing premium to incentivize drivers. Implement a fallback to on-demand dispatch if no driver pre-accepts.
Pricing Decision	Start simple: Locked-in Price = Estimated Fare + 10% Premium.
Cannibalization	This is likely incremental, capturing trips we would not get otherwise (e.g., airport rides). We will track this closely.
Operational Overload	Phase rollout to manage support load. Automated notifications and clear policies will reduce friction
Regulatory Compliance	Early engagement with local authorities to confirm required compliance

6. UX Proposal for Riders and Drivers

Rider Experience

A seamless experience is essential for adoption. The **Schedule a Ride** CTA should appear directly on the main booking screen.

Proposed journey:

Open Bolt → Tap "Schedule a Ride" → Select date & time (12h–30d) → Enter pickup & destination → Choose ride type → Confirm payment → Receive confirmation & reminders.

Features for riders:

- **Clarity:** Fare visibility at time of booking (locked in price) and confirmation of scheduled status.
- **Communication:**
24hour trip reminder, 60min driver assignment notification, driver arrival notification.
- **Reliability:** If no driver accepts by a set time (eg 60min) before pickup, system auto-initiates on-demand matching.
Optional round-trip planning for seamless travel.

Driver Experience

Drivers should retain autonomy while benefiting from the predictable income.

Proposed set up:

- **Autonomy:** Driver can opt-in for ride scheduling eg on/off toggle button "Available for scheduled rides".
- **Dashboard** of upcoming confirmed trips with earnings preview.
- **Incentives:**
Immediate earnings increase from premium payout
Priority Access: Most reliable drivers get first pick of high-value scheduled trips (eg airport) before other drivers are suggested to users
- **Navi-assistance/Planning:**
Real-time reminders and navigation alerts before scheduled pickups eg traffic situation alerts

7. Implementation Strategy

I propose a phased launch to allow rapid iteration and error mitigation with minimal exposure.

Phase 1: Proof of Concept Development & Validation (4-6weeks):

Build a high-fidelity prototype and run usability tests with power users to validate the UX flows and communication clarity.

Finalize the core pricing and matching algorithms with our Data Science team.

Check key regulatory requirements in targeted launch location(s)

Phase 2: Limited Alpha (4 Weeks):

Launch to Bolt employees who are key users in one city.

Test the entire operational stack end-to-end with a closed group. Focus on fixing driver-rider matching logic and notification timing.

Phase 3: City Beta (8 Weeks):

Launch to the public in a single, strategically chosen city with consistent demand patterns and minimal regulatory requirements for implementation.

Goal: Achieve and sustain a >98% fulfillment rate before considering a broader rollout.

Phase 4: Gradual Regional & Global Expansion:

Expand to additional cities based on a clear scorecard of success metrics from the beta.

Phase 5: Feature Updates

Recurring Rides: Enable weekly/daily scheduled rides for commuters.

Other feature updates.

8. Success Metrics

Category	Metric	Target (Pilot)
Adoption	% of active users using scheduling	>5% in 3 months
Reliability	% of rides starting within 5 minutes of scheduled time	>95%
Scheduled Rides Acceptance	% of scheduled requests accepted by drivers	>90%
Retention	30-day repeat scheduling rate	>40%
Revenue Impact	Incremental GMV from scheduled rides	+0.5%

Satisfaction	Rider NPS improvement vs regular rides	+15 points
Driver Quality	% of drivers achieving “Reliable” status	>25%

9. Final Recommendation

Bolt should **build** this feature. The strategic upside in user trust, retention, and revenue diversification is substantial. By prioritizing a flawless fulfillment rate over speed to market and adopting a phased rollout, we can transform a common user anxiety into a core competitive advantage. This feature is a strategic investment in making Bolt synonymous with reliability.

Overcharged Ride Ticket Reduction Analysis

Objective

To identify the key drivers of rider overcharge tickets and recommend product and operational changes to reduce their occurrence.

1. Preliminary Assumptions

Before analyzing the data, I tested the following hypotheses:

- **Dynamic pricing** (rush hours, weekends) increases perceived overcharges.
- **Low GPS confidence** leads to inaccurate distance calculations.
- **High rider fraud rating** may correlate with unsubstantiated claims.
- **Older driver app versions** could yield outdated pricing models.
- **Destination changes** often cause valid fare discrepancies.

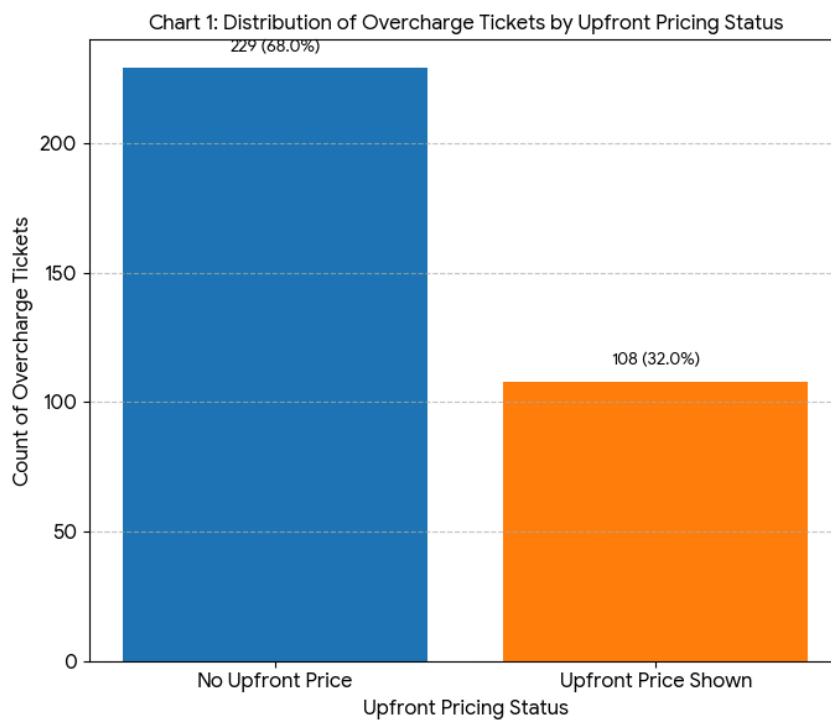
2. Actual Findings

Overcharge Issue	Ticket Count	% of Total Overcharge Tickets (N=337)
Missing upfront pricing	229	68%
Low GPS confidence	201	60%
High Price Deviation	77	23%

**Note: Issues often overlap; a single ticket can exhibit multiple factors.*

1. Missing Upfront Pricing (68% of Overcharge Tickets)

The biggest driver of overcharge complaints is the **absence of a locked-in price** before the trip. When a rider lacks a reference price, their expectation is based on previous trips or rough distance estimates. The resulting mismatch, particularly when surge or mapping issues apply creates perceived overcharging.



Distribution of Overcharge Tickets by Pricing Type

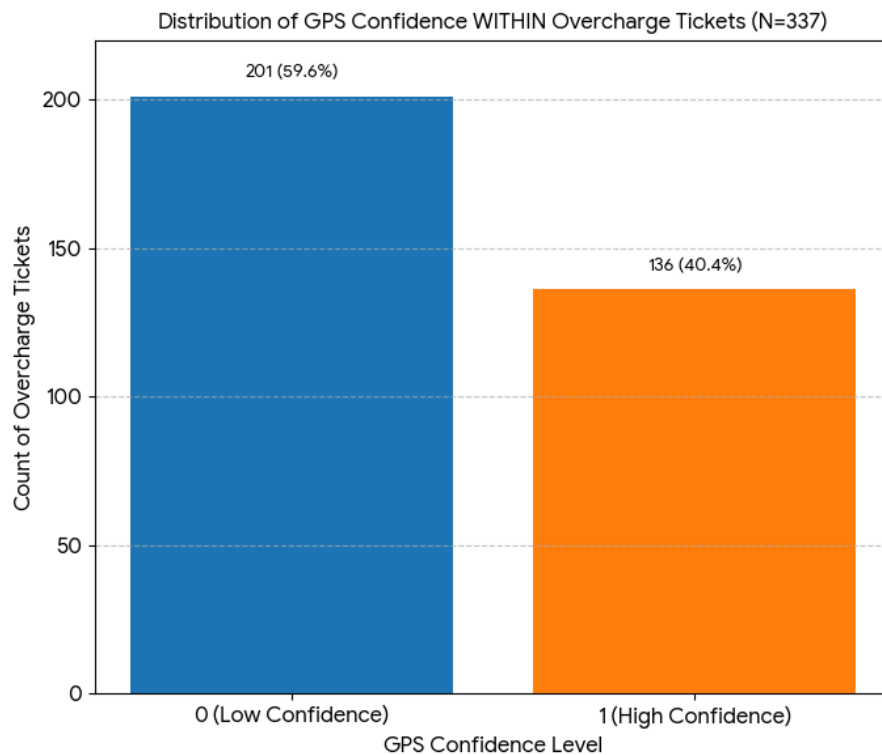
Recommendation

- **Provide In-Trip Fare Estimates:** For rides where a fixed upfront price isn't feasible, display a real-time estimated fare range to set accurate expectations.

2. GPS Confidence Issues (60% of tickets)

Three in five overcharged tickets occur during periods of low GPS confidence. This indicates that **location uncertainty** is a primary operational driver of inaccuracies. In environments with

poor signal (e.g. rural areas), distance estimation relies on unreliable coordinates, leading to a mismatch between the actual and billed distance.



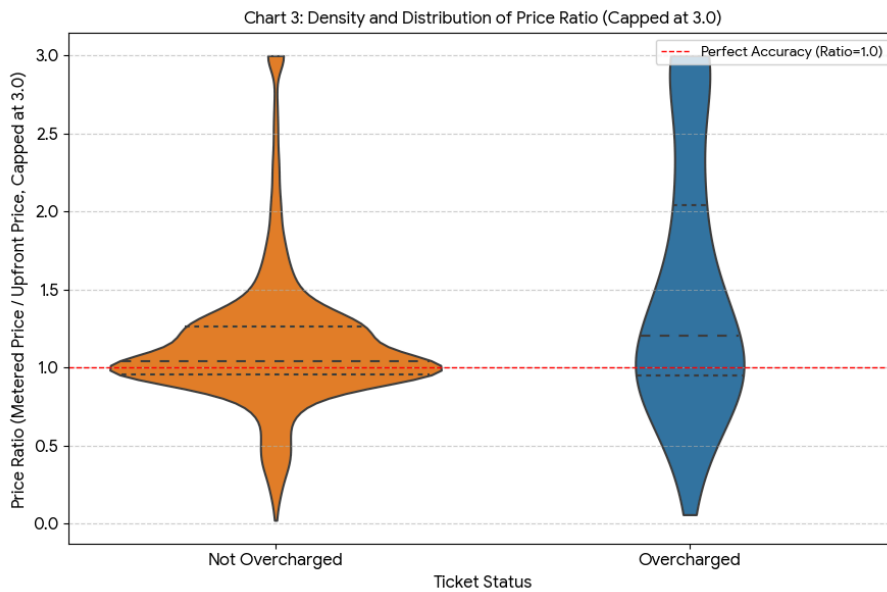
GPS Confidence Impact on Overcharge

Recommendation

- **Improve Mapping Accuracy:** enhance map data coverage in low-confidence areas.
- **Enable Manual Pin Drop:** Prompt riders to confirm or adjust their pickup and drop-off points manually when the GPS confidence is low.

3. Prediction Model Discrepancies

While missing upfront prices are the main issue, a portion of tickets also stem from **inaccurate upfront quotes**. When the initial prediction fails to account for real-world conditions like traffic or route deviations, the final price deviates from the quote, undermining rider trust—even though a price was provided.



Fare Prediction Accuracy vs. Actual Fare

Recommendation

- **Algorithm Review:** Recalibrate models to factor in real-time traffic and route changes.
- **Introduce Price Caps:** If the final fare exceeds 15% above the estimated price, proactively flag the ride for review or partial refund.

3. Remediation Plan

Timeframe	Action Items	Expected Result
Short Term (0–3 months)	Implement 15% price cap on predicted fares; automate partial refunds where exceeded. Identify most affected cities and investigate geo-mapping precision gaps. Notify riders proactively when GPS signal is weak or pricing confidence is low.	Addresses immediate price shock and manages expectations
Medium Term (3–6 months)	Introduce manual pin-drop for pickup points in low-confidence areas. Display updated fare estimates after destination changes and prompt riders to confirm.	Prevents inaccurate routes and builds trust

Long Term (6–12 months)	Develop a new price prediction model that adjusts to contextual variables in real time. Enhance in-app mapping and retrain prediction models with local data.	Structural reduction of overcharges and improved customer experience
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4. Conclusion

Overcharge tickets are primarily driven by a lack of price certainty (missing upfront fares) and technical inaccuracies (low GPS confidence). Inaccurate initial predictions compound this issue.

By implementing a strategy focused on transparent pricing, improved geo-accuracy, and proactive customer protection, Bolt can realistically target a 40–50% reduction in overcharge tickets within six months, thereby restoring rider trust and reducing support costs.